

POLITICS

Melania Trump's outfit was coded. She's a victim, but not Epstein's

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USA TODAY

Updated April 10, 2026, 3:48 p.m. ET

WASHINGTON – As [Melania Trump](#) walked into the Cross Hall of the White House to [deliver a statement](#) denying ties to the late convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein and decrying “fake images” of herself, she was dressed in a grey double-breasted Prada skirt suit.

It was the same outfit she wore as she co-signed the Take It Down Act, a law that aims to protect victims of deepfakes and revenge pornography, during an event at the Rose Garden last May. (The first lady's office confirmed to USA TODAY that it was the same suit.)

The unspoken message from this deliberate dresser? It was a callback to the day she co-signed the law she'd spearheaded to stop online harassment and threats.

Standing at the lectern on April 9, the first lady demanded that “lies” linking her to Epstein needed to stop immediately.

More: [Both in white, Melania and robot strut red carpet at White House](#)

“Numerous fake images and statements about Epstein and me have been circulating on social media for years now,” she said. “Be cautious about what you believe. These images and stories are completely false.”

She went on to characterize her social interactions with Epstein. saying they were in “overlapping social circles” and declared that she was not “Epstein’s victim” in a jaw-dropping statement lasting just under six minutes.

More: [Melania Trump denied Epstein ties. She may still have to testify, eventually.](#)

If the sartorial choice was meant to communicate a message, it was clear: She may not be a victim of Epstein’s, but she is a victim of social media.

The former model's fashion choices are often highly scrutinized, viewed as symbolic and spark conversation online.

More: ['The robots are here'. Melania Trump highlights AI as tech titans gather at White House](#)

Cases in point: The \$39 green Zara jacket with "I really don't care, do u?" printed on the back she wore during a visit to a Texas detention center for immigrant children in June 2018 caused an uproar. And she wore a fuchsia pussy-bow blouse to the second presidential debate in 2016, leading to speculation that it was a reference to a recently leaked tape with vulgar comments made by her husband.

Her film "Melania," released earlier this year, further bolsters the notion that she pays meticulous attention to her fashion choices and public image.

More: [Melania Trump denies connection to Epstein, blasts 'lies' and 'smears'](#)

“[Artificial intelligence](#) and social media are the digital candy for the next generation, sweet, addictive, and engineered to have an impact on the connectivity development of our children,” she said at the Take It Down Act signing. “But unlike sugar, these new technologies can be weaponized to shape beliefs and, sadly, affect emotions and even be deadly.”

Earlier this week, less than a year after the Take it Down Act was passed, a Columbus, Ohio man pleaded guilty to cybercrimes that included both real and AI-generated sexually explicit images and threats of violence to numerous victims.

“Today marks the first conviction under the Take It Down Act – protecting victims from non-consensual AI-generated sexually explicit images, cyberstalking, and threats of violence,” [the first lady wrote](#) on X.

Three days later, she presented herself as someone who knew what it was like to be at the receiving end of smear campaigns.

“My attorneys and I have fought these unfounded and baseless lies with success and will continue to maintain my sound reputation without hesitation,” she said.

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